HCP 1141 (cpc_1916-02-29_HU_Mezokovesd_HU_Szomolya_szomolya-21): a wartime love poem in numbers to Margitka Sziber

Human solver: Tomáš Pavuk

Status: deciphered in full (480 of 480 cipher signs, no unread word); three letters are taken by word sense; independent review 1 verdict ACCEPT, no letter changed. Report dated 2026-11-02.

Origin and context

The cryptogram is record 1141 of the HC Portal (https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1141), from Tobias Schrödel's collection of cryptographic postcards (private collection). When captured on 2026-11-02 the portal listed it as **Not solved**, category Substitution, language Unknown, sender Unknown, recipient Margitka Sziber, with no transcription or solution attached. The portal links a HistoCrypt article by Schrödel (https://ecp.ep.liu.se/index.php/histocrypt/article/view/166). A text search of that article finds no Margitka, Sziber, Szomolya or Mezőkövesd; its figures were not examined. No published solution of this card was found.

It is a picture postcard showing a couple at a fence, with no writing on the picture side except the collection stamp. All 24 lines of the message are enciphered; only the place and date are open, Mezőkövesd, 1916, II/29. That is 29 February 1916, a date that exists, as 1916 was a leap year. The postmark gives no usable date, so the date rests on the open line.

The open address reads: **Őnagysága / Szépreményű Sziber Margitka kisasszonynak / Szomolya / u. p. (Bogács) (Borsod m.)** ("To Her Ladyship, Miss Margitka Sziber of fair hope, Szomolya, post office Bogács, Borsod county"). The card belongs to a series sent from Mezőkövesd to Szomolya in north-east Hungary during the First World War. The writer signs in cipher as Árpád, as on the sister card hcp-1174.



Message and address side (source/address-large.jpg)



Picture side (source/picture-large.jpg)

The green figures near the bottom left and the circular stamp are collection marks, not part of the message.

Method

No earlier work on this number exists; the transcription and decipherment are by Claude Opus 5.5. The key was not recovered from scratch. It was started from the digit-and-mark table reconstructed on the finished sister cards hcp-1174, 1178 and 1179. That table read the opening at once (Édes Margitkám!, a napok, nélkül). The signs missing from it were fixed on this card and agree with the values on other cards of the series.

All 24 lines were transcribed by hand from the un-converted high-resolution scan, with 2x crops and 3x to 6x enlargements of doubtful marks. No OCR was used. The result has 480 signs in 96 words. Word gaps on the card are not consistent, so the word divisions are the solver's. A script checks the scan hashes, decodes every sign, and stops if any word differs from the stated reading. The verse layout and punctuation in its output are editorial; the check covers the letters.

Key

Monoalphabetic substitution of Hungarian, one sign per letter, with Hungarian digraphs as one sign. A sign is a digit plus an optional mark, and the mark changes the letter. In the register's terms this is MASC.

Sign	Plain	Sign	Plain	Sign	Plain
0	o, ó	2,	cs	5,	l
0,	ö, ő	2.	é	6	j
1	i, í	3	d	6,	n
1.	a	3,	r	6.	ny
1:	e	3.	v	7	k
1' (high dot)	á	4	f	7,	s
1,	b	4,	g	7.	sz
:1 (dots at left)	u, ú, ü, ű	4.	gy	8	m
2	c	5	h	8,	t
9	p	9,	z		

All 29 signs occur on this card. Short and long vowels are not separated, and :1 does not separate u from ü (rosszul, kunn, nélkül, üdvözletemet).

Plaintext

Sentence punctuation is partly editorial. The writer's own marks are the exclamation mark, the brackets, the colon after "az" and the commas after the verse words.

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Édes Margitkám!

A napok nállad nélkül nagyon rosszul telnek, de szeretnék legalább esténkint
együtt lenni vélled.

(Harctéri tudósítás) Galiciába megint támadnak az oroszok minden vonalon, de az
nem baj. Jelenleg többet nem írok. Majd írd meg, hogy megkaptad-e a lapokat.

Ott kunn a hó tornyosulhat,
jég is hullhat, szél is dúlhat,
megzörrentve ablakom)
soha nem panaszkodom,
mert szívemben itt van az:
édes kép, a friss tavasz.

Téged látlak mindég álmomban,
álmom után minden dolgomban,
ha sóhajtok érted a panasz,
ha víg vagyok érted vagyok az.
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Sok csókomat és üdvözletemet küldve maradok hű imádód a sírig (Árpád)

Mezőkövesd, 1916, II/29 (open)
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"nállad" and "vélled" (for nálad, véled) are spelled with a double l by the writer. "mindég" is a normal variant of mindig.

English translation

Sweet Margitka!

The days go very badly without you, but I would like to be together with you at least in the evenings.

(War report) The Russians are attacking into Galicia again on every line, but that does not matter. For now I write no more. Later write and tell me whether you received the cards.

Out there the snow may pile up, / ice may fall, wind may rage, / rattling my window; / I never complain, / for in my heart there is this: / a sweet image, the fresh spring.

You I see always in my dreams, / after my dream, in everything I do; / if I sigh, the lament is for you, / if I am merry, it is for you I am.

Sending many kisses and my greetings, I remain your faithful adorer unto the grave (Árpád)

Mezőkövesd, 29 February 1916.

Slovak translation

Moja sladká Margitka!

Dni bez teba ubiehajú veľmi zle, ale chcel by som byť s tebou aspoň po večeroch.

(Správa z bojiska) Rusi znova útočia do Haliča na celej línii, ale to nevadí. Teraz viac nepíšem. Potom mi napíš, či si dostala pohľadnice.

Vonku sa môže kopiť sneh, / môže padať ľad, môže zúriť vietor, / nech mi rachotí oknom; / nikdy sa nesťažujem, / lebo v srdci mám toto: / sladký obraz, svieža jar.

Teba vidím stále vo svojich snoch, / po sne vo všetkom, čo robím; / ak vzdychám, je to žiaľ za tebou, / ak som veselý, som ním pre teba.

Posielam veľa bozkov a pozdravov a zostávam tvoj verný ctiteľ až do hrobu (Árpád)

Mezőkövesd, 29. február 1916.

Why the reading is believed

477 of the 480 signs decode as written into continuous Hungarian with no unread word. The text is far too long and too varied for a forced fit: rhyme falls where it should (hullhat / dúlhat, ablakom / panaszkodom, az / tavasz, álmomban / dolgomban, panasz / az). Rare words come out unforced, such as tornyosulhat, megzörrentve and harctéri. The salutation, the closing "hű imádód" and the signature Árpád match the series, and the Russians in Galicia and the question whether cards arrived fit wartime 1916.

Uncertainties

Three letters are read against the bare table, each by word sense:

- **nállad**: the second 5 has a long flat foot and no separate comma, so the table gives h (nálhad). Read l; "vélled" has the same double l with both commas clear.
- **nagyon**: the last 6 has no comma, so the table gives j (nagyoj). Read n.
- **látlak**: the first 5 has no comma, so the table gives h (hátlak). Read l.

Other points:

- **kép**: the comma after the 9 stands well clear of it, unlike every real "9," on the card, so it is taken as punctuation. As part of the sign the word would be "kéz" (hand), which fits the sense worse. This word rests on mark position plus sense.
- **tudósítás**: the comma of the s touches the top of a 1 on the next line, so it is less clean than the others.
- **tavasz**: the last sign has a malformed foot, read as "7." with the dot merged. The rhyme az / tavasz supports sz.
- **imádód**: the á rests on a high dot beside the line-end hyphen. A second dot cannot be wholly excluded, but "imédód" is no word.
- **a lapokat**: a stroke leaves the left end of the section divider, rises through these two words and stops at the 7 of "lapokat". It may be a flourish or a partial strike of the phrase; this cannot be decided. The words read either way and are kept.
- **ablakom)**: a closing bracket with a short rule after it and no opening bracket. It is read as a mark, and its purpose is unexplained.
- **Free dots**: two dots after "panaszkodom", one of them above the 1 of "van" on the next line, are taken as a full stop and a stray. Neither forms a sign that changes a letter.
- **Galiciába** is illative (into Galicia) as written. Whether the report matches events in February 1916 was not tested, and the bracketed heading may be a joke.
- **Verses**: taken as the writer's own or popular verse. No printed source was sought.

Review and what changed

An independent Claude Opus 5.5 agent reviewed the card and tried to refute the reading. It ran the reproduction command, decoded the transcription with its own script and table, read all 24 lines of the high-resolution scan sign by sign against the transcription, and enlarged every disputed point 4x to 9x. It checked the key against sister cards and found no conflict. Its verdict was **ACCEPT**, with seven minor findings, none of which changed a letter of the plaintext.

Changes made in response:

- "után" and "tudósítás" are now transcribed as written (high-dot 1 and comma 7), not as sense readings. The count moved from 475 by the table and 5 by sense to 477 and 3.
- The blotted sign in "tavasz" and the free dots near "van" are now disclosed.
- The description of the stroke over "a lapokat" was corrected, and the earlier conclusion that it is only a divider was withdrawn.
- A stale header in the transcription file was fixed, the open date is given as "1916, II/29", and "de" is translated as "but" / "ale".

The reviewer could not verify the postmark, the match of the "war report" with events, or any printed source for the verses, and could not decide whether the stroke over "a lapokat" was meant as a deletion.

Reproduction

From the repository root:

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python3 -I ciphers/hcp-1141/work/decode.py
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It prints: 480 signs, 96 words, 477 by the table, 3 read by sense, 29 distinct signs, then the decode and plaintext.